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# From narrative to rules: the institutionalisation of EU 'de-risking' towards China, 2022–2024

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As the European Union (EU) has increasingly framed its China policy through the formula of "de-risking, not decoupling," a central analytical question is how this language becomes institutionally embedded in governance arrangements. Drawing on Strategic Narrative Theory, a CDA-informed textual analysis, and process tracing, this article examines how de-risking-related strategic language was progressively stabilised and recontextualised across EU policy and legal texts during 2022–2024, using the Foreign Subsidies Regulation (FSR) as the principal case and the Anti-Coercion Instrument and critical raw materials Act as auxiliary comparators. It asks how selected narrative elements become rendered actionable through legal categories, procedural thresholds, and administrative enforcement routines; why China's counter-narratives travel only partially within EU institutional settings; and how member-state heterogeneity conditions the scope and intensity of institutional embedding. The article develops a three-stage analytical pathway of narrative institutionalisation—discursive framing, institutional accommodation, and policy codification—as a mid-range heuristic for tracing how narrative claims acquire legal-bureaucratic form. Rather than claiming a direct clause-by-clause causal translation from discourse to law, the analysis argues that de-risking gains institutional traction insofar as economic-security concerns are rendered intelligible through ostensibly technical categories such as market distortion, fair competition, and supply vulnerability, thereby becoming reviewable and actionable within EU governance. China's counter-narratives remain constrained by normative misalignment, limited procedural translatability, and field-level gatekeeping, while member-state variation affects the scope and intensity of embedding without preventing convergence at Union level. By specifying how strategic language is stabilised in legal text and administrative practice, the article extends Strategic Narrative Theory in a more explicitly institutional direction.

KEYWORDS
**de-risking, Economic Security, EU–China relations, Foreign Subsidies Regulation, institutionalisation, regulatory governance, Strategic Narrative**

## 1 Introduction

In recent years, the European Union's (EU) China policy has moved away from a predominantly trade- and investment-oriented posture of "engagement" towards an economic-security approach increasingly framed as "de-risking" (Levy and Révész, 2022). A key discursive inflection came on 30 March 2023, when Commission President Ursula von der Leyen, speaking at

the MERICS–EPC event in Brussels, articulated the formula "de-risking, not decoupling" and called for selectively reducing dependencies on China in critical raw materials, sensitive technologies, and strategic infrastructure while preserving broader commercial exchange (European Commission, 2023). While this shift has been widely recognised in the literature, the main analytical challenge is not simply to restate the rhetorical turn, but to explain how risk language becomes stabilised within the EU's governance architecture.

Existing scholarship has offered rich accounts of the political-economy drivers behind the EU's economic-security turn, but it has less fully specified the institutional pathways through which de-risking is rendered durable in concrete policy arrangements. Three issues remain under-examined. First, how do narrative elements enter policy architectures in ways that produce legal-bureaucratic form—such as definitions, thresholds, procedures, and enforcement competences—rather than remaining at the level of general policy orientation? Second, what role do China's counter-narratives play in EU institutional arenas, and why are their effects limited? Third, how does intra-EU heterogeneity condition implementation, not only through member-state preferences but also through the legal room for manoeuvre embedded in EU rules (Brinza et al., 2024; European Think-tank Network on China, 2024; Fabry and Courtial, 2025)? To reflect the evolving state of the art, the article also engages selectively with recent policy research published in 2025, while retaining 2022–2024 as its principal empirical window.

Against this backdrop, the article asks how the EU's de-risking Strategic Narrative becomes institutionally embedded within the EU's governance architecture and rendered actionable through policy arrangements. Rather than treating institutionalisation as a generic movement from discourse to "tools," the analysis focuses on how selected narrative elements are stabilised in legal categories, procedural thresholds, and administrative enforcement routines. Methodologically, the article combines Strategic Narrative Theory (SNT) with a CDA-informed textual analysis and process tracing. Using the EU's Foreign Subsidies Regulation (FSR) as the principal case, it reconstructs a time-ordered analytical pathway through which de-risking-related language acquires legal-bureaucratic form, examines the constrained uptake of China's counter-narratives in EU settings, and assesses how intra-EU heterogeneity conditions implementation through both political preferences and legal discretion.

The analysis suggests that the EU's de-risking narrative is institutionally stabilised through an analytical pathway of discursive framing, institutional accommodation, and policy codification. One central finding is that economic-security concerns gain traction when they are expressed through ostensibly technical categories such as "fair competition" and "market distortion," thereby becoming administratively reviewable within EU governance. At the same time, member-state heterogeneity and the constrained circulation of China's counter-narratives jointly shape the scope and intensity of institutionalisation. The article makes two contributions. First, it proposes an operationalisable mid-range model of narrative institutionalisation that links discourse analysis to textual evidence at the level of legal and policy provisions without presuming a single uniform causal mechanism. Second, it specifies the boundary conditions of institutional embedding created by member-state politics and by the legal room for manoeuvre built into EU rules. In this respect, while Miskimmon et al. (2014) foreground narrative formation and dissemination, the present model places greater emphasis on institutional embedding, procedural uptake, and policy guidance, offering an empirically tailored extension for EU–China relations. The remainder of the article proceeds as follows. Section 2 reviews the literature and elaborates the theoretical framework. Section 3 sets out the research design and methodology. Section 4 presents the empirical analysis, tracing how strategic language is embedded within policy and legal texts. Section 5 examines the boundary conditions of institutional embedding, with particular attention to the limited uptake of Chinese counter-narratives and the role of member-state heterogeneity. Section 6 concludes by summarising the main findings and contributions, outlining avenues for future research, and discussing the broader implications of the analysis.

# 2 Literature review and theoretical framework

## 2.1 The evolution, framing, and strategic interpretation of EU de-risking

### 2.1.1 From engagement to systemic rivalry: the hardening of the EU'S China narrative

Scholarly accounts broadly agree that the EU's narrative on China has shifted from a predominantly cooperative framing to a more contested and security-inflected representation, culminating in the consolidation of China as a 'systemic rival' in European policy discourse (Kaveshnikov and Lupaltsova, 2024). Existing research is persuasive in explaining this hardening in relation to broader geopolitical change, especially the escalation of US–China rivalry, the diffusion of 'decoupling' debates, and growing concern over dependency, coercion, and strategic vulnerability (Drezner, 2021; Brühl, 2024; Garcia-Macia and Goyal, 2021).

What remains less fully specified, however, is how such changing perceptions were translated into institutional language, policy categories, and operational instruments within the EU itself. In other words, the literature has explained why EU perceptions of China changed more effectively than how those shifts acquired legal-bureaucratic form within EU governance.

### 2.1.2 The rise of the 'de-risking' strategy and its framing

It is against this background that 'de-risking' emerged as the EU's preferred formula for recalibrating China policy. The literature generally treats this shift not as an abrupt rupture, but as a gradual rearticulation of how China-related vulnerabilities should be identified, justified, and governed. In March 2022, the EU's *Strategic Compass for Security and Defence* reiterated the tripartite positioning of China as a partner for cooperation, an economic competitor, and a systemic rival, signalling that EU strategic cognition had become increasingly linked to geopolitics, institutional competition, and 'technological sovereignty' (Council of the European Union, 2022a). In this context, technological sovereignty refers to the capacity of a political community to research, develop, deploy, and regulate key technologies without external control or coercion (Kokas, 2023).

The 2023 *European Economic Security Strategy* further consolidated this shift by embedding China-related concerns within a broader economic-security framework oriented towards mitigating strategic dependencies and supply-chain vulnerabilities (Brinza et al., 2024; Mehling, 2025). Rather than marking a complete break with the past, this development also reflected growing scepticism towards the earlier expectation—often associated with *Wandel durch Handel*—that deepening economic interdependence would gradually induce political convergence in China (Wacker, 2025).

In EU debates, de-risking is generally understood not as severing economic ties with China, but as reducing vulnerabilities through the identification, assessment, and mitigation of specific risks such as concentrated dependencies, geopolitical exposure, and supply-chain disruption (Brinza et al., 2024). This orientation is often summarised through the 'Promote–Protect–Partner' triad: promoting resilience and industrial capacity, protecting strategic sectors through defensive and screening instruments, and partnering selectively with China in limited areas such as climate governance and other global public goods (Brinza et al., 2024). Existing research has therefore clarified what de-risking means and how it is framed in EU policy discourse. What it has not yet adequately explained is how this framing is translated into stable institutional forms. That is the analytical task taken up in this article.

### 2.1.3 Analysing 'de-risking' through the lens of Strategic Narrative Theory

Strategic Narrative Theory (SNT) provides a useful starting point for analysing de-risking because it highlights how political actors construct meaning at the levels of system, identity, and policy (Miskimmon et al., 2014). Existing scholarship on de-risking has already shown that the EU increasingly redefines China's place in the international system and redraws the boundaries of acceptable interdependence. This article uses SNT not simply to restate those frames, but to clarify how selected narrative claims are rendered policy-actionable within EU governance.

From this perspective, de-risking operates across three interlocking narrative layers. At the system level, China is increasingly represented as a systemic rival whose practices are seen as challenging the rules-based international order. At the identity level, the EU's self-representation as a normative power—an actor claiming authority to shape rules, values, and legitimate standards of conduct—helps justify risk reduction as consistent with the Union's wider external identity (Sugiono and Haris, 2025). At the policy level, these broader claims are translated into instruments that convert political concerns into administrative categories and intervention points, including subsidy control, anti-coercion measures, raw-material resilience, and foreign-investment screening (Miskimmon et al., 2014; Babić et al., 2024).

The FSR is especially important in this regard because it illustrates how narrative priorities can be stabilised in procedural and enforceable form. Article 17, for example, empowers the Commission to investigate and exclude bidders benefiting from foreign subsidies in public-procurement procedures, thereby linking notions such as 'fair competition' and 'strategic autonomy' to concrete regulatory practice (Hornkohl, 2023). Read through SNT, the significance of such provisions lies not simply in their legal content, but in their institutional role as interfaces through which narrative meaning is rendered administratively usable within routine decision-making. This also reveals a limitation in much existing SNT-inspired work: while it is strong on narrative formation, legitimation, and dissemination, it is less precise on how narratives are embedded in legal-bureaucratic architectures. The present article addresses that gap by placing greater analytical weight on institutional embedding, procedural uptake, and policy guidance.

### 2.1.4 Strategic heterogeneity among EU member states

A further issue insufficiently integrated into the literature is the role of intra-EU heterogeneity. The EU does not speak with a perfectly uniform voice on China, and member-state variation continues to shape how de-risking is interpreted, prioritised, and implemented. Some scholarship captures these differences through the shorthand contrast between post-2004 entrants, often grouped as 'New Europe', and longer-standing members, sometimes labelled 'Old Europe', while also noting that substantial internal variation remains within both clusters (Sverdrup-Thygeson, 2024). Here, 'New Europe' refers broadly to member states that joined the EU after 2004, including the Baltic states and the Visegrád Group. In recent years, several of these countries have moved away from earlier engagement-oriented approaches and towards positions more closely aligned with US security framings of China-related risks (Sverdrup-Thygeson, 2024).

By contrast, major Western European economies remain more deeply shaped by sectoral exposure and domestic political constraints. Germany, for example, counted China as its largest trading partner for eight consecutive years from 2016 to 2023 (Destatis, 2024). High dependence in sectors such as automobiles and chemicals has often encouraged a form of 'strategic ambiguity', whereby support for EU-level de-risking measures coexists with caution in public positioning on issues regarded as particularly sensitive by Beijing, such as Taiwan (European Think-tank Network on China, 2024). France, meanwhile, combines increasingly risk-conscious language with a stronger emphasis on European strategic autonomy, including through defence cooperation and industrial protection (Charon et al., 2023; European Think-tank Network on China, 2024).

The trajectory of Central and Eastern Europe is often discussed through the rise and subsequent contraction of the '16+1' framework launched by China in 2012. As geopolitical conditions changed and the balance between expected economic gains and perceived strategic risks shifted, Lithuania, Estonia, and Latvia withdrew from the mechanism around 2022, signalling a sharper turn towards risk-oriented approaches more closely aligned with the United States (European Think-tank Network on China, 2024). For the purposes of this article, the key point is not simply that heterogeneity exists, but that it conditions how narratives are stabilised politically and then translated institutionally. Existing scholarship often treats member-state variation as contextual background; this article instead treats it as a constitutive condition of narrative institutionalisation.

### 2.1.5 The construction and response of China's counter-narrative strategies

The EU's turn towards de-risking has not gone uncontested. China has responded by advancing strategic counter-narratives designed not only to reject the EU's precautionary framing, but also to reframe the normative terms of policy debate. Through the BRI, the GDI, and the GSI, China promotes institutional pluralism and the legitimacy of forms of 'non-Western modernity', that is, developmental pathways

not anchored in Western liberal-democratic norms (Dessein, 2024; Di Ciommo et al., 2024). China also promotes a discourse of global governance reform centred on true multilateralism, extensive consultation, and a more inclusive international order, while rejecting bloc confrontation and ideological division (Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the People's Republic of China, 2024; Dessein, 2024). Beyond Europe, these narratives are reinforced through recurring claims about non-interference and common development, which have generated resonance in parts of the Global South (Dessein, 2024; Di Ciommo et al., 2024).

China's response to de-risking combines critique with selective reassurance. On the critical side, official statements and policy texts such as *Join Hands to Build the Belt and Road: A Major Practice in Building a Community with a Shared Future for Mankind* portray de-risking as a form of ideological containment and as an instrumentalisation of economic interdependence. From an EU perspective, however, such claims are often read as attempts to weaken normative scrutiny and recast risk as a neutral or purely technical matter, thereby intensifying contestation at the policy level (European Commission, 2023; Dessein, 2024). At the same time, Chinese counter-narratives are not purely confrontational. Dessein (2024) characterises China's approach as one of 'silent pragmatism', through which Beijing foregrounds practical cooperation—such as infrastructure investment and public-health assistance—while often avoiding direct ideological confrontation with Europe. In this sense, claims about 'win–win cooperation' and 'resilience-based cooperation' may be read as efforts to preserve room for engagement even as the EU shifts towards de-risking (Tudoroiu, 2022). Xi Jinping's statements in 2023–2024 similarly reiterated partnership-oriented language, stressing openness, common development, and win–win cooperation while criticising the politicisation of trade and economic exchange (Xi, 2023; Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the People's Republic of China, 2024; State Council Information Office, 2024). External commentary has interpreted these interventions as an effort to preserve room for engagement and to moderate the EU's precautionary framing (Chatham House, 2024; Asia Society Policy Institute, 2024).

Yet existing research has not sufficiently explained why the diffusion of these counter-narratives remains institutionally limited inside the EU. Some studies show that China can shape signalling or rhetorical positioning among selected member states, including Greece and Hungary, and that it can create pockets of discursive moderation within Europe (Brinza et al., 2024). But they say less about why such narratives struggle to acquire clause-based support inside EU legal and administrative frameworks. The key issue, therefore, is not only whether China offers alternative meanings, but whether those meanings can be translated into EU-compatible policy guidance, governance categories, and review procedures.

## 2.2 Research gaps and problem formulation

The existing literature provides a strong foundation for understanding the emergence of de-risking as a central frame in EU China policy. It has explained the geopolitical and political-economy drivers of the EU's shift, mapped the discursive rise of China as a "systemic rival," and identified the presence of Chinese counter-narratives in both bilateral and multilateral settings (Kaveshnikov and Lupaltsova, 2024; Brinza et al., 2024). It has also shown that member-state preferences vary and that such variation shapes the broader political environment of EU China policy. What it has not yet fully clarified, however, is how Strategic Narratives move beyond framing and contestation to become embedded in institutional structures and rendered actionable within concrete governance arrangements.

This gap is visible in three respects. First, existing work has not sufficiently examined how abstract narrative concepts are stabilised as semantic anchors within policy texts. Second, it has not adequately specified how member-state heterogeneity conditions the accommodation, stabilisation, and contestation of narrative alignment within the EU's multi-level governance structure. Third, the processes through which narrative elements are rendered actionable through definitional work, discretionary criteria, procedural thresholds, and administrative instruments remain under-specified. To address this gap in institutional embedding, the present article proposes a Three-Stage Model of Narrative Institutionalisation, tracing movement from discursive framing through institutional accommodation to policy codification.

The model should be understood as a mid-range analytical heuristic rather than as a fully specified behavioral mechanism. It does not assume that discourse is automatically translated into law, nor that each stage unfolds as a uniform causal sequence across all policy domains. Instead, it clarifies how selected narrative elements may move from problem definition and legitimation, to institutional accommodation within a heterogeneous multi-level setting, and finally to codified provisions, procedures, and remedies. In this sense, the model is positioned closer to an ideational-institutional account of embedding than to a claim of direct clause-by-clause causal transmission from discourse to law.

Against this backdrop, the article asks how the EU's de-risking Strategic Narrative becomes embedded within the EU's institutional environment and rendered actionable in governance arrangements towards China. To answer this question, the analysis takes as its principal case the FSR—especially the Preamble and Articles 2–6 of Regulation (EU) 2022/2560—to examine how de-risking-related language is stabilised in normative formulations, policy guidance, and enforceable clauses. The ACI and the CRMA are used as auxiliary materials to compare how similar narrative elements are embedded across different policy domains, thereby illustrating variation in pathways of institutionalisation and policy effects. The article also addresses two boundary questions: why China's counter-narrative strategies encounter obstacles when they seek to enter EU normative and procedural frameworks, and how member-state heterogeneity affects the scope and depth of de-risking's institutional embedding.

Finally, complementary work from Asian scholarship further illuminates the normative premises underlying this competition. Chang and Pieke (2018), for instance, show how Chinese political thinking associated with a "Community of Shared Future for Mankind" frames EU–China interaction around mutual respect and non-interference. Yang (2021) analyses the international-relations implications of this narrative through the lens of China's "Legalist turn," while He (2019) explores related forms of activism in China's global political thought. These contributions are important because they foreground non-Western conceptions of order and challenge the EU's self-positioning as a normative power. At the same time, they do not yet explain how such competing narratives are rendered actionable—or fail to be rendered actionable—within EU policy guidance, institutional procedures, and concrete regulatory instruments. It is

precisely this unresolved question of institutional embedding that the present study seeks to address.

## 3 Methodology

This study adopts an embedded multiple-case design to examine how the EU's de-risking narrative is institutionally embedded in policy instruments vis-à-vis China. The principal case is the Foreign Subsidies Regulation (FSR), selected because it provides a clear illustration of how risk-oriented political language can be rendered into legal categories, procedures, and enforceable governance rules (Ding and Zhang, 2024). Substantively, the FSR links competitive order to economic-security concerns by specifying and scrutinising foreign subsidies in ways that reshape the boundary conditions of EU–China economic interaction (Fabry and Bertolini, 2025). It is also methodologically suitable because it offers a recoverable legislative sequence, from Commission proposal in 2021 to adoption in 2022, together with a relatively compact legal corpus that permits close textual analysis.

To reduce single-case bias, two cognate EU instruments—the ACI and the CRMA—are used as systematic comparators. These instruments allow the analysis to assess whether similar narrative elements are embedded across different regulatory domains while keeping the main inferential focus on the FSR. In addition, auxiliary contrastive materials are used to clarify boundary conditions for institutionalisation, including the trajectory of the CEE "16+1" framework and divergent German–French approaches to China. These materials are not treated as full cases, but as structured contextual references that help illuminate the limits of China's counter-narratives and the effects of member-state heterogeneity.

Methodologically, the study combines a CDA-informed textual analysis with process tracing and structured cross-document comparison. The discourse-analytical component is anchored primarily in Fairclough's three-dimensional conception of text, discursive practice, and social practice, but is situated more broadly within critical discourse studies, especially scholarship on discourse, power, ideology, recontextualisation, and institutional uptake. In this article, CDA is applied in a bounded and selective way: at the textual level, it examines lexicalisation, evaluative wording, modality, and technicised legal phrasing in key EU texts; at the level of discursive practice, it traces how risk language is recontextualised across speeches, strategy papers, legislative documents, and legal instruments; and at the level of social practice, it situates these discursive shifts within the EU's wider economic-security turn, member-state heterogeneity, and the institutional gatekeeping that shapes which narratives become policy-actionable. Process tracing is used more modestly to reconstruct a time-ordered sequence through which selected narrative elements move from political signalling into policy guidance and institutional text, thereby clarifying how strategic language acquires procedural and legal form, rather than to claim a fully demonstrated causal chain from discourse to law (Fairclough, 1992, 1995; van Dijk, 2008; Wodak and Meyer, 2015; Fairclough and Fairclough, 2012). The article does not claim to provide an exhaustive linguistic CDA of all relevant texts; rather, it uses a bounded CDA-informed framework to analyse how selected lexical, intertextual, and institutional features help convert political language into administratively actionable governance categories (Wodak and Meyer, 2015; van Dijk, 2008). Nor does it infer direct clause-by-clause drafting causation from lexical correspondence alone. Instead, it reconstructs a patterned and time-ordered pathway through which de-risking-related language becomes increasingly available, legitimate, and institutionally actionable across EU policy and legal texts.

At the level of theoretical operation, the article employs a Three-Stage Model of Narrative Institutionalisation to guide the empirical analysis (see Figure 1): discursive framing, referring to problem definition, legitimation, and the stabilisation of semantic anchors; institutional accommodation, referring to the recontextualisation of narrative language into procedural and organisational forms that can absorb heterogeneity within the EU's multi-level governance system; and policy codification, referring to the consolidation of narrative elements into provisions, procedures, and remedies that make institutional arrangements executable. The model is used as an analytical pathway rather than as a claim to a uniform causal sequence. More specifically, it is intended to clarify stages of institutional embedding, not to reconstruct all micro-level bargaining episodes or to posit a single behavioural mechanism operating identically across cases.

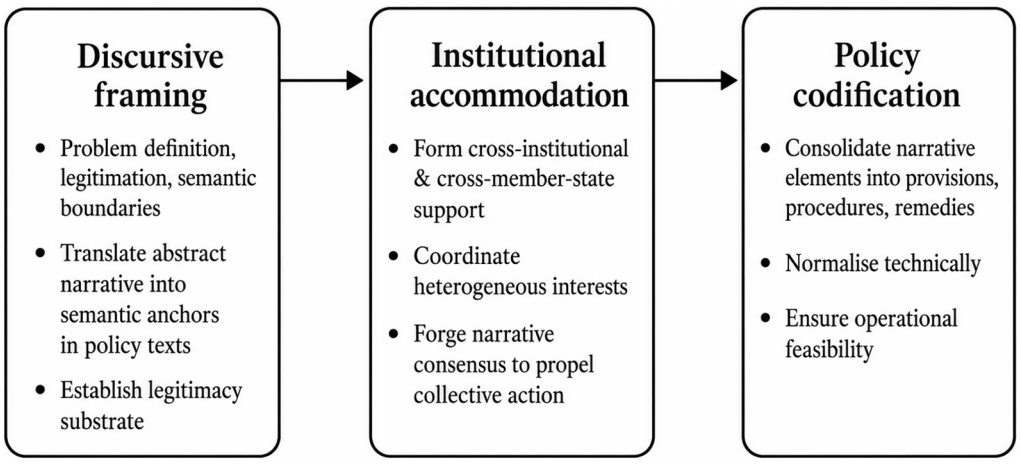



FIGURE 1
Three-Stage Model of Narrative Institutionalisation.

The analysis draws on two principal classes of material. The first consists of EU legislative and policy texts, most notably the FSR, with the ACI and CRMA used as comparators. The second consists of representative speeches and institutional documents, including Ursula von der Leyen's 30 March 2023 speech at the MERICS–EPC event in Brussels as an authoritative articulation of the de-risking narrative. These materials are supplemented by the FSR legislative sequence, European Parliament legislative records, and European think-tank reports for triangulation. To incorporate the counter-narrative dimension, the study also uses Chinese sources, including the State Council Information Office's (2023) white paper Join Hands to Build the Belt and Road: A Major Practice in Building a Community with a Shared Future for Mankind and Xi Jinping's 2023–2024 statements on EU–China relations. These texts are analysed to identify recurring counter-narrative elements such as "win–win cooperation" and "peaceful development," and to trace how Beijing seeks to reframe de-risking through the language of resilience and cooperation (Huang, 2023). Where the analysis discusses the EU-side filtering or limited uptake of such counter-narratives, these claims are treated as institutionally inferred unless directly supported by EU-side documentary evidence. The temporal window and thematic scope of the materials are aligned with the research questions to ensure traceability between evidence and explanation.

Reliability was assessed using Krippendorff's $\alpha$. Two independent coders—the author and a research assistant—conducted inter-coder checks on a 20% random sample of the coded corpus, proportionally drawn from the main EU texts and auxiliary materials. NVivo's coding-comparison function yielded $\alpha = 0.85$, which exceeds the conventional 0.80 benchmark for high reliability; remaining discrepancies were resolved through iterative adjudication (see Figure 2).

## 4 Empirical analysis: from discourse to rules—the institutionalisation pathway of "de-risking"

The empirical analysis is organised around the article's Three-Stage Model of Narrative Institutionalisation, while each stage is examined through the bounded CDA-informed framework set out in Section 3. Section 4.1 focuses primarily on the textual dimension, Section 4.2 on discursive practice through recontextualisation and institutional accommodation, and Sections 5.1–5.2 on the broader social-practice conditions that shape differential narrative uptake.

This section takes the FSR as the principal case, complemented by the ACI and the CRMA, and combines a CDA-informed textual analysis with process tracing and structured cross-document comparison to examine how de-risking-related strategic language becomes institutionally embedded in EU governance. Rather than claiming a fully demonstrated causal sequence from discourse to law, the analysis reconstructs a patterned and time-ordered pathway of institutionalisation composed of three analytically linked stages: discursive framing, institutional accommodation, and policy codification. The empirical backbone is dual-track coding in NVivo 14, organised as "01_Topic-Content Class" and "02_Strategic-Narrative Dimension." The coding produced more than 180 coded references. Inter-coder reliability was assessed on a random 20 per cent subset of the corpus (approximately 2,000 words) and yielded a Krippendorff's $\alpha$ of 0.85, which supports the consistency of category application. Triangulation relies on four checks: coding density across sections, semantic co-occurrence patterns, cross-textual consistency across EU instruments, and time-ordering evidence from the legislative sequence. Taken together, these

**Data Sources Summary**

| Source type | Key documents | Link to model stage |
|---|---|---|
| EU policy & legislation | FSR; ACI; CRMA | **Policy codification** (primary); also discursive framing via semantic anchors and risk construction. |
| EU speeches & institutional docs | von der Leyen (Brussels, 2023); Economic Security Strategy | **Discursive framing** (problem definition, legitimation); supports institutional accommodation (cross-institutional signalling). |
| Think-tank briefs & EP records | MERICS; ECFR; European Parliament records | **All three stages:** triangulation; external perspectives; member-state heterogeneity. |
| Chinese sources | SCIO BRI White Paper (2023); Xi's 2023 EU–China statements | **Discursive framing & policy codification** (counter-narrative elements; selective policy translation). |

FIGURE 2
Data sources and their linkage to the Three-Stage Model of Narrative Institutionalisation.

materials do not establish clause-by-clause drafting causation. They do, however, support a bounded institutional interpretation of how selected political narrative elements become administratively actionable and are subsequently stabilised in rule-based governance.

## 4.1 Discursive framing: semantic anchoring and the institutional language of legitimacy

At the discursive-framing stage, the de-risking agenda draws on a legitimacy lexicon that links risk, norms, and sovereignty in ways that can be rendered administratively actionable in legal text. In the FSR, the Preamble and the definitional provisions provide the main semantic anchors. At the textual level, the analysis focuses not only on semantic anchoring, but also on lexicalisation, evaluative wording, modality, and technicised legal phrasing. Recital (2) repeatedly frames the problem as "foreign subsidies distorting the internal market" [Regulation (EU) 2022/2560, Recital (2)]. From a text-level CDA perspective, this lexicalisation performs an important institutional function: it renames a broad political and strategic concern in market-governance terms and thereby renders it reviewable through administrative procedures. "Distortion" is therefore not merely a descriptive term, but a technicised legal phrasing that transforms a diffuse concern into an object of procedural scrutiny.

In terms of conceptual scope, Article 3(2)(b) specifies that a financial contribution may include the "foregoing of revenue… such as tax exemptions" [Regulation (EU) 2022/2560, Art. 3(2)(b)]. This wording expands the operational space of review by allowing tax-type preferences to fall within the compliance perimeter. Regarding the presumption of distortion, Article 4(1) states that where a subsidy "improves the competitive position of the undertaking in the internal market and thereby negatively affects competition in the internal market" [Regulation (EU) 2022/2560, Art. 4(1)], distortion may be inferred. Here, evaluative wording such as "negatively affects competition" provides a normatively loaded yet legally operational formulation for identifying actionable concern. At the same time, Article 4(2) introduces a general de minimis threshold, stating that foreign financial contributions that "not exceed EUR 4 million" over a three-year period are "unlikely to distort" (Regulation (EU) 2022/2560, Art. 4(2)). This modal phrasing is significant because it manages uncertainty while setting an administratively usable intervention threshold. Taken together, these provisions show how a macro-level narrative concern is rendered administratively manageable through definitional scope, inference logic, and thresholds.

In parallel, political discourse provides the broader narrative provenance for the legal text. President von der Leyen's 30 March 2023 speech at the MERICS–EPC event in Brussels reiterated "de-risking, not decoupling" and advanced the Promote–Protect–Partner triad as organising language for the EU's approach (European Commission, 2023). The Economic Security Strategy (June 2023) then positioned instruments such as the FSR within a consolidated policy "toolbox," helping stabilise the linkage between political vocabulary and institutional design (European Commission and High Representative of the Union for Foreign Affairs and Security Policy, 2023). These contemporaneous texts are used here as contextual triangulation rather than as direct causal proof of drafting choices.

A limited amount of process-level support can nevertheless be drawn from the FSR's legislative sequence. The Commission's original proposal of 5 May 2021 already framed foreign subsidies as a problem of distortion in the internal market and as a level-playing-field issue, while linking that framing to concrete procedural devices, including notification-based review, *ex officio* investigation, and possible redressive measures (European Commission, 2021). The Council's negotiating mandate of 4 May 2022 retained this basic problem-definition and regulatory orientation, and the provisional political agreement reached between the Council and the European Parliament on 30 June 2022 indicates that the core architecture was preserved through inter-institutional negotiation (Council of the European Union, 2022b,c). On the Parliament side, the legislative record shows that MEPs sought greater legal certainty and transparency, including more detailed guidance on the balancing test, additional reporting and notification-related safeguards, and a broader toolkit of redressive measures, before Parliament adopted its first-reading position on 10 November 2022, which corresponded to the final legislative act (European Parliament, 2022, 2024). This sequence does not demonstrate that any single political speech directly produced clauses. It does, however, provide process-level evidence that the internal-market vocabulary of distortion, fair competition, and reviewable intervention was carried, refined, and stabilised across the Commission, Council, and Parliament during the ordinary legislative procedure (European Commission, 2021; Council of the European Union, 2022b,c; European Parliament, 2022). To make the comparison between the EU narrative and China's counter-narrative more transparent, the table below summarises a cross-document mapping of selected key terms and their narrative functions.

Table 1 shows that the EU's de-risking narrative gains traction through terms that are not only politically resonant but also legally and administratively operationalisable. By contrast, Chinese counter-narrative formulations such as "win–win cooperation" and "peaceful development" remain more normatively expressive than procedurally actionable within the EU's compliance-centred governance setting.

## 4.2 Discursive recontextualisation and institutional accommodation

This recontextualisation is visible not only in the shift from political formulations such as "de-risking, not decoupling" to the policy "toolbox" language of the Economic Security Strategy, but also in the legislative sequence through which internal-market vocabulary was retained and refined across the Commission, Council, and Parliament.

At the level of discursive practice, the key issue is not coalition formation in a strictly behavioral sense, but how de-risking-related language is recontextualised into institutional design features that can accommodate heterogeneity within EU governance. At this stage, policy language such as "fair competition" and "market distortion" is translated into a structured review architecture capable of coordinating implementation without presupposing full political convergence among member states. Article 10 (Preliminary review) and Article 11 (In-depth investigation and types of decisions) establish a tiered logic that differentiates screening from investigation and links both to decision outcomes [Regulation (EU) 2022/2560, Arts 10–11]. This tiering provides a common procedural pathway while still allowing variation in how cases are filtered, prioritised, and escalated.

More importantly, Article 6(1) introduces a balancing test that requires the Commission to weigh "the negative effects… against the positive effects" [Regulation (EU) 2022/2560, Art. 6(1)]. This proportionality-based language functions as an institutional buffer. It does not eliminate political disagreement, but it provides a shared justificatory grammar through which divergent member-state preferences can be accommodated within a single enforcement framework. In this sense, the Regulation does not demonstrate coalition formation directly;

TABLE 1 Cross-document mapping of selected key terms and their narrative functions.

| Key term/phrase | Source text | Narrative function in the article |
|---|---|---|
| "de-risking, not decoupling" | von der Leyen speech (30 March 2023) | Reframes China policy around selective risk reduction rather than full economic separation |
| Promote–Protect–Partner | von der Leyen speech (30 March 2023) | Provides a political organising triad for the EU's de-risking approach |
| "Foreign subsidies distorting the internal market" | FSR, Recital (2) | Converts a broad strategic concern into a reviewable legal object |
| "Negatively affects competition" | FSR, Art. 4(1) | Supplies an evaluative but legally operational criterion for identifying actionable concern |
| "Unlikely to distort" | FSR, Art. 4(2) | Introduces modal phrasing that manages uncertainty through an administratively usable threshold |
| policy "toolbox" | European Economic Security Strategy (2023) | Stabilises the linkage between strategic vocabulary and institutional design |
| "Win–win cooperation"/"peaceful development" | Chinese official discourse (counter-narrative materials used in the study) | Offers a cooperative alternative framing to the EU's compliance-centred language |

rather, it shows how institutional design can absorb heterogeneity by embedding disagreement within a common procedural logic.

The auxiliary instruments reinforce this accommodation logic in different policy domains. The ACI channels heterogeneous member-state inputs into a unified response by empowering the Commission to conduct investigations and coordinate countermeasures [Regulation (EU) 2023/2675, Art. 9] (European Parliament and Council of the European Union, 2023). The CRMA, in a different domain, organises collective commitments around supply-chain resilience by setting Union-level benchmarks and coordination requirements designed to reduce vulnerability in critical raw materials governance [Regulation (EU) 2024/1252, Art. 5]. Together, these instruments support the interpretation of the FSR as part of a wider institutional interface through which de-risking-related language is stabilised across the EU's economic-security framework (European Commission, 2023).

## 4.3 Policy codification: institutional translation and counter-narrative tension

At the policy-codification stage, the FSR translates the problem definition into enforceable categories and decision powers. In public procurement settings, the Regulation introduces the category of an "unduly advantageous" tender [Regulation (EU) 2022/2560, Art. 27]. This category institutionalises the idea that subsidy-driven advantages can be treated as a compliance issue rather than as a purely commercial outcome. In terms of decision types, Article 31(2) empowers the Commission to issue a "decision prohibiting the award of the contract… [and to] reject the tender" [Regulation (EU) 2022/2560, Art. 31(2)]. This provision clarifies the enforcement endpoint of the review pathway. Regarding commitments and remedies, Recital (24) and Article 7(4)(h) establish a verifiable repayment option, including repayment "together with appropriate interest" [Regulation (EU) 2022/2560, Recital (24); Art. 7(4)(h)]. This creates a compliance route that substitutes remedial measures for structural distortions in certain cases.

A horizontal comparison indicates that other instruments in the broader economic-security toolbox extend similar logic into adjacent domains. The ACI functions as a deterrence-and-response framework against third-country economic coercion and protects EU policy autonomy, while the CRMA operationalises supply security through sectoral targets and monitoring obligations. The three instruments therefore complement each other by translating de-risking-related policy vocabulary into rule-based governance capacities across competition, coercion, and supply chains (European Commission, 2023). The point here is not that a single discourse label is mechanically codified across all instruments, but that a broader economic-security framing becomes stabilised through differentiated legal-bureaucratic forms.

## 4.4 Dedicated comparison: applying the three-stage model to the FSR, ACI, and CRMA

Across the three instruments, narrative institutionalisation follows distinct semantic anchors, coordination devices, and codified enforcement interfaces. The FSR anchors contestation in "market distortion" [Regulation (EU) 2022/2560], the ACI foregrounds "economic coercion" [Regulation (EU) 2023/2675, Recital 1], and the CRMA centres "supply-chain vulnerability" and strategic autonomy [Regulation (EU) 2024/1252, Art. 1]. In institutional-accommodation terms, the FSR's balancing test (Art. 6(1)) enables coordination under member-state heterogeneity, the ACI relies on Commission-led investigations and countermeasures (Arts 9–10), and the CRMA mobilises collective benchmarks for resilience (Art. 5). At the codification stage, each instrument translates its anchor into executable procedures and remedies. For the FSR, this takes the form of procurement-related review and redressive measures [Arts 27, 31; Recital 24; Art. 7(4)(h)]; the ACI relies on restrictive or compensatory response measures, while the CRMA introduces benchmark-based monitoring and strategic-project designation. Rather than demonstrating a uniform causal chain from discourse to law, the comparison shows how a common economic-security framing is differentially embedded across adjacent regulatory domains.

# 5 Boundary conditions of institutional embedding

## 5.1 Limited EU-side uptake of China's counter-narratives: documentary indications and institutional inference

At the level of social practice, this pattern reflects a broader EU economic-security environment in which member-state

heterogeneity, compliance-oriented governance, and field-level gatekeeping condition which narrative claims become procedurally actionable and which remain normatively visible but weakly embedded.

China's counter-narrative—commonly articulated through themes such as "win–win cooperation" (互利共赢), "peaceful development" (和平发展), and "development first" (发展优先)—seeks to contest the EU's de-risking narrative, which increasingly foregrounds securitisation and compliance-oriented governance. The materials examined in this study, however, provide only limited EU-side evidence that such Chinese formulations were incorporated into the operative vocabulary of Union-level economic-security governance. Across the European Economic Security Strategy, the FSR, the ACI, and related EU policy texts, the dominant categories remain market distortion, economic coercion, resilience, vulnerability, fair competition, and risk mitigation rather than "win–win cooperation" or "shared development." The issue, therefore, is not simply discursive disagreement, but the institutional conditions under which narratives must become legible, actionable, and stabilised within EU governance.

This does not demonstrate the total absence of Chinese influence in European debates, nor does it exclude selective rhetorical moderation in particular member states or sector-specific settings. It does suggest, however, that within the institutional sites analysed here, Chinese counter-narratives did not acquire clause-based, reviewable, or procedurally stabilised form in the EU's core economic-security instruments. To the extent that stronger claims about EU-side "filtering" or "limited uptake" go beyond explicit documentary statements by EU actors, they are treated here as institutional inferences derived from the absence of translation into EU policy categories, procedures, and legal provisions. On this basis, the analysis identifies three closely related explanations for the constrained institutional circulation of China's counter-narratives within the EU: normative misalignment, limited procedural translatability, and field-level gatekeeping within the EU's economic-security architecture (European Commission and High Representative of the Union for Foreign Affairs and Security Policy, 2023, p. 7).

A first explanation concerns normative misalignment. EU institutions operate through a vocabulary centred on market integration, fair competition, distortion review, and rule-based governance. Economic Security is articulated less through broad political signalling than through policy toolboxes, review procedures, and corrective measures (European Commission and High Representative of the Union for Foreign Affairs and Security Policy, 2023, p. 7). By contrast, Chinese discourse often foregrounds development priorities, mutual benefit, and cooperative order. Texts such as *China's Peaceful Development* (《中国的和平发展》) repeatedly emphasise "peaceful development" (和平发展) and "win–win outcomes" (互利共赢) as the basis of external engagement (State Council Information Office, 2011). These principles may carry political resonance, but they do not map neatly onto the EU's compliance-centred legal idiom. When narratives must be rendered intelligible through categories of distortion, risk screening, and remedial proportionality, a semantic mismatch emerges that reduces interpretive compatibility (European Commission, 2023). Chinese responses often recode this asymmetry as ideological containment and counter it with appeals to "genuine multilateralism" (真正多边主义) and broader global-governance reform (State Council Information Office, 2023), but this does not by itself resolve the problem of institutional translation.

A second explanation concerns limited procedural translatability. Narratives are more likely to be durably absorbed into EU governance when they can be translated into thresholds, review pathways, disclosure requirements, and remedial options. Chinese counter-narratives often remain broader political principles rather than operational interfaces. This is visible in Belt and Road discourse that stresses cooperation, connectivity, and shared prosperity. Xi Jinping's speeches, including *Working Together to Advance the Belt and Road Initiative* (《携手推进"一带一路"建设》) and later Belt and Road Forum addresses, repeatedly invoke "a community with a shared future" (命运共同体) and related claims such as "humanity forms a community with a shared future" (人类是相互依存的命运共同体) (Xi, 2017, 2023). Such formulations can be normatively attractive, but they do not readily supply the definitional anchors, technical indicators, or decision pathways through which EU instruments organise compliance review. This helps explain why Chinese official discourse increasingly advocates the de-ideologisation of global governance as a corrective orientation. In *China's Proposals on the Reform and Development of Global Governance* (《中国关于全球治理的改革和发展建议》), the Ministry of Foreign Affairs calls for "co-building, co-sharing, and win–win outcomes" (共建共享共赢) and more inclusive governance arrangements (Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the People's Republic of China, 2024). Yet within EU institutional settings, principles that cannot be translated into reviewable procedures remain weakly embedded.

A third, more interpretive explanation concerns field-level gatekeeping. The EU's multi-level institutional architecture—especially the Commission, Council, and Parliament—structures which claims become actionable and which remain external to authoritative policy vocabularies. The Anti-Coercion Instrument (ACI) is illustrative here. By centring the category of "economic coercion," it consolidates a security-oriented agenda and organises the field around deterrence and response [Regulation (EU) 2023/2675, Recital (5)]. Chinese discourse responds with alternative frameworks such as the Community of a Shared Future for Mankind (构建人类命运共同体) and "genuine multilateralism" (真正多边主义), as seen in the white paper *Building a Community with a Shared Future for Mankind: China's Proposals and Actions* (《携手构建人类命运共同体:中国的倡议与行动》) and Xi's address at the CPC in Dialogue with World Political Parties High-Level Meeting (State Council Information Office, 2023; Xi, 2023). These narratives provide moral and political alternatives to the EU's agenda-setting logic, but they encounter structural barriers when they cannot cross institutional thresholds in EU-compatible procedural form.

This does not mean that Chinese counter-narratives are uniformly excluded from all European arenas. Conditional uptake may occur where cooperation is framed in project-specific or sector-bounded terms, and where implementation is mediated by member-state preferences, subnational actors, or technical procurement and financing arrangements. Such uptake, however, tends to remain localised and does not fundamentally reorient the Union-level compliance framework. The central problem, therefore, is not merely the existence of alternative narratives, but the institutional terms under which they can become actionable without displacing the EU's core categories of review, risk assessment, and remedy.

## 5.2 How member-state heterogeneity shapes the scope of embedding

Member-state divergence is not simply an implementation obstacle. It is a structural condition that shapes how far and how

deeply de-risking can be institutionalised across the EU. The typology used here should be understood as an analytical simplification based on three dimensions relevant to economic-security governance—trade exposure, security concern, and industrial structure—rather than as a comprehensive classification of all member states.

A first posture may be described as high exposure with prudential adjustment, exemplified by Germany, where dense trade and investment ties with China encourage a balancing strategy between industrial competitiveness and risk mitigation (Destatis, 2024). A second is a strategic-autonomy and institutional-guardrail posture, exemplified by France, which is more inclined to support robust screening, localisation, and industrial-defence instruments as part of a broader European autonomy agenda (Charon et al., 2023). A third is an Atlanticist security-first posture, associated with the Baltic states and parts of Eastern Europe, where China-related risk is framed more strongly through security concerns and support for deterrence-oriented tools. A fourth is a pragmatic transactional posture, observable in parts of Southern Europe, where cooperation remains more acceptable in selected sectors and local economic opportunity can carry greater weight.

Such heterogeneity does not prevent convergence at Union level because the institutional process contains mechanisms of absorption and consolidation. In the FSR, proportionality reasoning and balancing tests create limited discretion within a common compliance framework, allowing broader public-interest considerations to be weighed alongside negative market effects in enforcement decisions [European Parliament and Council of the European Union, 2022, Regulation (EU) 2022/2560, Art. 6(1)]. More broadly, tiered review procedures and notification thresholds channel diverse national preferences into a unified legal pathway. Similar dynamics are visible in instruments such as the CRMA, where diversification of critical raw materials supply is framed as a Union-level objective capable of aligning different national profiles under common targets and monitoring logics [European Parliament and Council of the European Union, 2024, Regulation (EU) 2024/1252]. The result is that member-state differences rarely disappear, but are partially absorbed through procedural design. This helps explain why de-risking is institutionalised not as a perfectly uniform project, but as a graduated and managed one: political contestation may shape the scope and intensity of embedding, yet it does so within a common compliance-oriented architecture whose core procedural logic remains largely intact.

## 6 Conclusion

This article has examined how the EU's de-risking Strategic Narrative becomes institutionally embedded in its policy towards China. Using the FSR as the principal case, and the ACI and CRMA as auxiliary comparators, the analysis suggests that de-risking gains institutional traction not simply because it circulates as a persuasive political formula, but because selected elements of that strategic language are rendered administratively actionable through legally reviewable categories, procedural thresholds, and enforcement routines. More specifically, the article has reconstructed a patterned and time-ordered pathway through which economic-security concerns are recontextualised in ostensibly technical frames such as fair competition, market distortion, and supply vulnerability, thereby stabilising strategic meaning in rule-based governance. In this sense, the institutionalisation of de-risking is not best understood as an external addition to EU policy, but as part of the process through which political language acquires legal-bureaucratic form.

The article makes two main contributions. First, it develops a Three-Stage Model of Narrative Institutionalisation—discursive framing, institutional accommodation, and policy codification—to clarify how Strategic Narratives may move from semantic anchoring to executable governance arrangements within the EU. This extends Strategic Narrative Theory in a more explicitly institutional direction by specifying how narrative meaning can be stabilised through legal text, procedural design, and enforcement competence, rather than through formation and dissemination alone. The model is offered as a mid-range analytical heuristic for tracing narrative embedding, not as a claim to a single uniform causal sequence or a fully specified behavioural mechanism across all cases. Second, the article identifies the boundary conditions of institutional embedding. China's counter-narratives travel only partially within EU institutional settings because they face normative misalignment, limited procedural translatability, and field-level gatekeeping. At the same time, member-state heterogeneity shapes the scope and intensity of embedding, but does not preclude convergence at Union level because proportionality tests, balancing clauses, and tiered review procedures allow political differences to be accommodated within a common compliance-oriented framework.

The key question, therefore, is not simply which side offers a more persuasive narrative, but which types of claims can be rendered reviewable, actionable, and durable within a given governance system. This also indicates the limits of symmetrical comparison: in the present case, the EU's institutional architecture gives greater traction to narratives that can be codified through compliance-based procedures, whereas broader development-centred counter-narratives remain only partially embedded and, where EU-side reception is not directly documented, are best understood through bounded institutional inference rather than direct process evidence. Future research could extend this analysis by examining whether similar narrative-embedding dynamics operate in other domains of EU external economic governance, and by tracing more systematically how third-country actors respond when Strategic Narratives are stabilised through regulatory instruments rather than through diplomacy alone.

## Data availability statement

The original contributions presented in the study are included in the article/Supplementary material, further inquiries can be directed to the corresponding author.

## Author contributions

YL: Conceptualization, Methodology, Formal analysis, Investigation, Data curation, Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft.

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## Supplementary material

The Supplementary material for this article can be found online at: https://www.frontiersin.org/articles/10.3389/fpos.2026.1832759/full#supplementary-material

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## Appendix. Core source corpus and coding transparency

This article draws on four core source clusters: EU political conclusions, European Parliament resolutions, EU legal texts, and Commission implementation materials. The principal documents include the European Council conclusions on China (30 June 2023), the European Parliament resolution on EU–China relations (13 December 2023), Regulation (EU) 2022/2560 on foreign subsidies, and the Commission's implementation materials on the Foreign Subsidies Regulation.

A full source list, source-to-model mapping table, coding scheme, inter-coder reliability notes, and NVivo query settings are provided in Supplementary file S1. Replication materials are anonymised for review; a public repository link will be added upon acceptance.

The Figure A1 is included for descriptive transparency only. It is not treated as a stand-alone finding and does not constitute independent discourse-analytic evidence. The interpretive weight in Section 4.1 rests on coded references, lexical analysis, and article-level legal provisions.




FIGURE A1
Term-frequency word cloud from the FSR corpus (NVivo 14). Stop-words removed; stemming applied. Corpus: Preamble and Articles 2–6 of Regulation (EU) 2022/2560.